

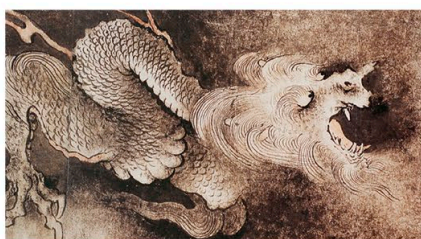
960-1279

LIFE IN SONG CHINA

While much of Europe laboured under a feudal system, citizens of Song China lived in peace in a land of thriving cities and expanding trade. Under a succession of eight emperors, the Northern Song dynasty employed a meritocratic bureaucracy to oversee civic life. Peasants were attracted to live in the wealthy cities, some of which grew to house more than a million people. Commerce flourished along newly built canals, and entrepreneurs financed trading expeditions to Japan and southeast Asia in multi-decked junks guided by the world's first magnetic compasses. Transactions were made simpler by a money economy of copper coins and the world's first printed banknotes.

The metropolitan elite enjoyed a lifestyle featuring theatres, restaurants, and social clubs devoted to pursuits including poetry, art, cuisine, and horse-riding. Widespread literacy was encouraged by large-scale paper production and the introduction of woodblock printing. Technological innovations included gunpowder and the first firearms, while booming industry saw cast-iron production reach a record 125,000 tonnes (138,000 tons) in a year.

Even after the northern lands were lost to invaders in 1127, prosperity continued under the Southern Song centred on Lin'an (today's Hangzhou). A further century and a half passed before the dynasty finally succumbed to Mongol invaders in 1279.



KEY MOMENTS

1005 Keeping the peace

After 25 years of intermittent warfare, the Song signed a treaty with the Liao Empire on their northern border, paying them an annual tribute in silver and raw silk (*left*) in return for an end to hostilities.

1070 New economic policies

Faced with a growing budget deficit, the Song appointed the philosopher Wang Anshi (*left*) as chancellor. His reform programme targeted tax evasion by the wealthy and addressed growing social inequality. The policies were resisted by landowners and the merchant guilds but proved successful.

1127 Jurchen invaders capture Bianjing

China's northern border was breached when Jurchen raiders took the capital and captured the emperor and his heir. The emperor's younger son set up a new court south of the Yangzi River, initiating the Southern Song period (*Southern Song dragon pictured left*).

